

Phrase

A phrase is a group of related words standing together as a unit within the syntax of a sentence. Phrases function as parts of speech within a sentence thus; a sentence is made up of phrases.

How to Identify a Phrase

- If the verb in the sentence starts with 'to' then it is a non-finite verb thus, a phrase.

Example.

He is always ready to fight anybody

To pass examination is hard work

- If the verb functions as an adjective, it is a non-finite verb and therefore a phrase.

Example

I have boiled yam in my pot

The flying horse is bad

- If the verb in the sentence is in the 'ing form' then it is a phrase.

Example

Eating late is what I hate

I saw the boy going to school

Types of Phrases

- The Noun phrase.
- The Adjectival phrase.
- The Verb phrase
- The Adverbial phrase and
- The prepositional phrase.

The Noun Phrase

A noun phrase is a phrase that has the noun or pronoun as its head word. It can be a single noun, a noun + a pronoun, a noun + determiner, a noun + a preposition, a noun + a post modifier.

Eg. A single Noun = boy

Noun + a determiner/article = the boy, a cap, an umbrella

Noun + a pronoun = my brother, your umbrella, her car

Noun + a post modifier =

Noun + preposition = behind the door

A noun phrase has the noun or pronoun as its head word and can be pre-modified by an article/determiner, an adjective, a pronoun and preposition. The pronoun can be possessive or demonstrative.

Eg. Your umbrella

That umbrella.

The noun phrase can also be post modified by adjective, prepositional phrase, or adjectival/relative clause.

In example (1) the noun phrase is pre-modified by the definite article 'the'.

In example (2) the noun phrase is pre-modified by the possessive pronoun '**your**'.

In example (3) the noun phrase is pre-modified by the demonstrative pronoun '**that**'.

Eg. Something terrible has happened.

Here, '**terrible**' is an adjective and a post modifier of the noun phrase '**something**'. Thus in this case, we have a pronoun '**something**' as the head word of the noun phrase.

Eg. The boy in the room is my nephew. Here, the noun phrase, '**the boy**' is post modified by the prepositional phrase '**in the room**'.

Eg. The boy who came in is my uncle's son. Here, we have an adjective or a relative clause '**who came in**' functioning as a post modifier of the noun phrase '**the boy**'.

Grammatical Functions of the Noun Phrase

1. A noun phrase functions as the subject of the verb in a sentence.
A subject is a word or phrase which performs the action or acts upon the verb in a sentence. The following are examples of noun phrase functioning as the subject of the verb in a sentence.
 - The armed robbers** have invaded the city.
 - The boy** in the room is my friend.
2. A noun phrase functions as object of the verb in a sentence.
 - I met **the new English teacher** = here, '**the new English teacher**' is the noun phrase functioning as the object of the verb '**met**'.
 - His dad suspended **the programme**.
 - The man bought **a T-shirt**.
3. A noun phrase functions as object complement of preposition. When a noun phrase functions as object complement of preposition, it comes immediately after the preposition.
 - The boy **behind the door** is a thief. Here, you have '**the door**' functioning as the complement of the preposition '**behind**'.
 - The little girl gave her pen **to her brother**. Here, '**her brother**' is the noun phrase complementing the preposition '**to**'.
4. The noun phrase functions as object complement. An object complement is a word, phrase or clause that directly follows and describes the direct object of a sentence.
 - We made him **our class representative**. Here, '**our class representative**' is the noun phrase functioning as the complement of the object '**him**' in the sentence.
5. A noun phrase also functions as subject complement.
 - The brilliant girl is **my friend**. Here, '**my friend**' which is a noun phrase functions as the complement of the subject, **the brilliant girl**.
 - John is **a student**. Here, '**a student**' is the complement of the entire sentence.

6. The noun phrase functions as an appositive. An appositive is a word, phrase or clause that modifies or gives more information about the subject in a sentence.
- Mr. Tammy, **our new English teacher** is a good teacher. Here, '**our new English teacher**' which is a noun phrase is in apposition to the noun phrase '**Mr. Tammy**'.
- Baba, **the musician** is very rich. Here, '**the musician**' is in apposition to the noun phrase '**Baba**'.

Adjectival Phrase

An adjectival phrase is a word or group of words that act as an adjective in a sentence to give more information about a noun or pronoun. Adjective phrase usually starts with an adjective, adverb or preposition.

Example: My dog was extremely tired after going on a hike with me.

The car covered in mud is mine.

She wore very expensive shoes.

Grammatical Functions of the Adjectival Phrase

1. It functions as attributive adjectives. Attributive adjective phrase typically sits before the noun it modifies.

Example: fat men seldom run fast.

The slim lady is my wife.

2. Adjectival phrase functions as predicative. A predicative adjective comes after the noun it modifies using linking verb.

Example: those questions are tough

The man looks stupid.

3. Adjectival phrase functions as post modifiers.

Example: the boy with a brown cap is my class mate.

The fund available will not be enough for the project.

4. Adjectival phrase functions as nouns.

Example: The rich are usually unmindful of the poor.

The government should cater for the needy.

5. Adjectival phrase functions as the complement to a finite or non-finite clause.

Example: To speak in class is **very difficult** for some students. Here, '**very difficult**' is an adjectival phrase functioning as complement to the non-finite clause '**to speak in class**'

-What he did is **totally unacceptable**. Here, '**totally unacceptable**' is an adjectival phrase which complements the finite clause '**what he did**'.

6. Adjectival phrases pre-modify nouns,

Example: Extremely loud sound.

Very intelligent young man.

7. Adjectival phrases functions as subject complement and object complement.
Example: The singer is exceptionally good. Here, '**exceptionally good**' is an adjectival phrase complementing '**the singer**' which is the subject of the sentence.
He made his children very useful. Here, '**very useful**' is an adjectival phrase complementing '**his children**' which is the object of the sentence.

Adverbial Phrase

Adverbial phrase is a phrase that has the adverb as its head word. An adverb phrase consists of one or more words. The adverb is the head of the phrase and can appear alone or it can be modified by a fellow adverb or even an entire sentence.

Grammatical Functions of the Adverb phrase

1. It functions as a modifier in an adjectival phrase. In the instances below.
 - Your piercingly loud scream has broken the silence. Here, '**piercingly**' is an adverbial phrase pre-modifying the adjectival phase, '**loud**' in the sentence.
 - Employees who are regularly absent will be disciplined.
2. It functions as a head in adverbial phrase.
Eg. Quite separately. Here, 'separately' which is also an adverb is functioning as the head in the adverbial phrase '**quite separately**'. Other examples are;
Incredibly quickly
Quickly enough
3. It functions as modifier in adverbial phrase.
Eg. **Quite** separately (we kept the money **quite separately**)
Really carefully (he drives **really carefully**)
4. It functions as a modifier of verb.
Eg. He sings **very well**. Here, '**very well**' is an adverbial phrase modifying the verb '**sings**'
I eat **quite healthy**. Here, '**quite healthy**' is an adverbial phrase modifying the verb '**eat**'.
5. It functions as adverbial. Adverbial is a word, phrase or clause that modifies a verb, an adjective or an entire clause by providing information such as time, place, manner, reason, condition, frequency and concession.
Eg. Husbands should speak for their wives **adoringly** (manner)
Ade drove the car **outside** (place)
They **almost never** invite people to their house these days.(degree)

Verb Phrase

A verb phrase is headed by a verb. It functions primarily as predicate in the structure of a clause/sentence. The verb phrase like other phrases has a modifier and a head word. The modifier is an optional element while the head word is an obligatory element. Lexical verbs functions as head word in the structure of a verb phrase whereas auxiliary verbs functions as modifiers in the structure of a verb phrase. In the examples below, the heads are emboldened while the modifiers are not.